

DEBORIS LEONARD

AI Strategy & Transformation | AI Adoption & Enablement | Operating Cadence | Leading Through Influence

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EXECUTIVE PROFILE

AI strategy and transformation leader with 10+ years driving technology adoption across a large, regulated enterprise. Leads a cross-functional portfolio of predictive and generative AI models delivering over \$200M in enterprise value. Provides operational leadership for data science, engineering, product, and clinical stakeholders, building the operating cadences, roadmaps, and measurement practices that turn emerging AI into accountable organizational change. Doctoral researcher who builds measurement before intervention, quantifying where AI output and human judgment diverge from ground truth.

AI STRATEGY AND TRANSFORMATION CAPABILITIES

- AI strategy and executive alignment
- AI transformation roadmaps
- Operating cadence and working-group leadership
- Leading through influence, not authority
- Product and engineering partnership
- AI adoption and impact measurement
- AI learning and stakeholder enablement
- Generative AI, RAG, and LLM evaluation
- Emerging AI landscape translation
- Responsible AI and model risk

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Principal Technical Program Manager | Optum AI | UnitedHealth Group

2025 - Present

- Lead a generative AI initiative delivering a RAG-based contract analytics and reasoning platform for enterprise procurement, aligning product, engineering, data, and business stakeholders around a new AI-enabled way of working.
- Own strategy execution and operating cadence for a portfolio of 15+ healthcare AI/ML models delivering \$120M in enterprise value, primarily through medical cost savings.
- Run the recurring working groups and executive readouts that keep data science, ML engineering, product, business SMEs, governance, and operations focused on roadmap sequencing, dependencies, and deployment readiness.
- Drive decisions through influence by translating technical constraints and model limitations into candid recommendations, escalation paths, and executive ready narratives.
- Build measurement and reporting across intake, model evaluation, SME validation, stakeholder signoff, and post-launch outcome tracking.
- Translate emerging AI capabilities into practical guidance that raises organizational AI fluency and accelerates responsible adoption.

Senior ML Architect and Manager, Data Engineering and Architecture | WellMed | UnitedHealth Group

2021 - 2025

- Managed engineers and analysts, including employees and contractors, delivering enterprise data, analytics, and ML capabilities in a regulated healthcare environment.
- Led adoption playbooks, refactor coordination, and enterprise data dictionary development for model-enabled suspect generation workflows supporting more than 1M patients.
- Architected hybrid cloud and on-premise infrastructure supporting more than 5 TB of clinical data, improving scalability, reliability, and governance alignment.
- Partnered across product, data science, engineering, privacy, security, and business functions to translate strategy into executable platform and model delivery plans.

Product Delivery Manager | CaptureRx

2020 - 2021

- Directed cross-team delivery for analytics and data platform initiatives, aligning product priorities, engineering execution, stakeholder expectations, and release readiness.
- Introduced acceptance-test-driven practices within CI/CD pipelines to improve delivery quality, accountability, and operational control.

Product Owner and Release Train Engineer | Optum Technology | UnitedHealth Group

2018 - 2020

- Coordinated multiple engineering teams delivering enterprise analytics and AI-enabled platforms, managing planning cadences, dependencies, milestones, and shared commitments.

Senior Project Manager | UnitedHealthcare | UnitedHealth Group

2016 - 2018

- Led enterprise technology modernization initiatives supporting analytics-driven healthcare operations and delivered approximately \$6M in annual operational improvements.

EDUCATION, RESEARCH AND PUBLICATION

Doctor of Philosophy, Advanced and Equitable Computing, Morgan State University | In Progress

- Research builds measurement infrastructure for AI evaluation: reliability, bias, and ground-truth divergence in AI-generated feedback and multilingual speech systems, including where model output and human judgment disagree.

Publication: Leonard, D., Gole, R., and Dacon, J. (2026). Prescriptive Persistence: Quantifying the Breakdown in Human-AI Pedagogical Co-Regulation in ELL Writing Feedback. ACM Learning at Scale, 202-208.
doi.org/10.1145/3774398.3811611

Master of Science, Data Science, Ball State University | 2022

Bachelor of Science, Management, DeVry University | 2016

TECHNICAL FLUENCY

Generative AI: retrieval-augmented generation (RAG), LLM evaluation, prompt design, OpenAI API, Anthropic Claude API

AI and ML: Python, R, SQL, PySpark, Scikit-learn, PyTorch, TensorFlow, Azure ML

Cloud and Data: Azure, AWS, Snowflake, hybrid cloud architecture, CI/CD

Responsible AI: model evaluation, bias testing, risk documentation, mitigation tracking, deployment readiness, post-launch accountability

MILITARY LEADERSHIP

United States Air Force, Technical Sergeant E-6, 2002 - 2012 | Retired and Honorably Discharged

Meritorious Service Medal | Air Medal | Aerial Achievement Medal